

DECISIVE MOMENT July 14, 1789 1:30 p.m.–5:30 p.m.

Storming of the Bastille

In the summer of 1789 a revolution broke out in France against the despotic government of Louis XVI. Many different factors caused this revolution, but the one event that symbolized the collapse of royal power in the face of widespread popular dissent was the storming of the Bastille prison on July 14, 1789.

Built between 1370 and 1383 as part of the walled defenses of Paris, the Bastille first became a prison for high-ranking state prisoners during the early 17th century. It also served as an arsenal, storing large quantities of gunpowder and arms. In 1789 the prison was defended by 18 cannons and 12 smaller artillery pieces manned by a regular garrison of 82 *invalides*—veteran soldiers no longer fit for active service—and reinforced by 32 grenadiers from a Swiss mercenary regiment summoned to Paris by the king some days before.

On July 14, rumors spread through Paris that troops were marching on the city to crush dissent against the king. Responding to this threat, a crowd of between 600 and 1,000 strong, armed with weapons seized from the Hôtel des Invalides, a military hospital, assembled in front of the Bastille to acquire its arsenal and defend their city from attack.

At around 10:30 a.m. the first of two delegations met the governor of the Bastille, Bernard-René de Launay, asking him to distribute its weapons to the crowd. Both delegations were unsuccessful. By 1:30 p.m., the crowd

had lost patience, and surged into the undefended outer courtyard. Gunfire rang out, although it is unclear which side first opened fire. At around 3 p.m., a detachment of 62 mutinous Gardes Françaises arrived at the prison armed with two cannons, which they placed in front of the gates leading to the inner courtyard. As fighting intensified, de Launay threatened to blow up the fortress; but the soldiers within the garrison surrendered, forcing him to open the gates.

At 5:30 p.m., the crowd stormed the prison. The governor was led away to the *Hôtel de Ville*, the town hall, where he was stabbed to death, along with at least two defenders. One defender and 98 attackers died in the actual fighting, with another 73 attackers wounded.

The news of the fall of the Bastille spread quickly across France, prompting uprisings in many cities. In reality, the prison was an almost empty symbol of royal tyranny—it held a mere seven prisoners—but the storming did signify that power had now passed from those who discussed political change to those who took direct action to achieve it.

First blood

One of the first victims of the storming of the Bastille was its governor, Bernard-René de Launay, shown here, surrounded by soldiers. He was seized by the mob, stabbed to death, and then decapitated. His head was stuck on a spike and paraded through the streets of Paris.

“It was the **best** of times, it was the **worst** of times.”

CHARLES DICKENS, *A TALE OF TWO CITIES*, 1859

